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Timothy Kuhn. *What Do Corporations Want? Communicative Capitalism, Corporate Purpose, and a New Theory of the Firm*. Bristol University Press, 2024. 258 pp. \$40.95, paper.

At first glance, the title of Timothy Kuhn's book may seem to anthropomorphize the firm, but Kuhn's goal is the opposite: to challenge the idea that firms have singular, unified intentions. Kuhn is a professor of communication at the University of Colorado Boulder and an expert in organizational communication, particularly studying how communication practices shape organizations, authority, knowledge, and value. The book aims to influence how sociologists, organizational researchers, and strategic management scholars understand for-profit organizations. In *What Do Corporations Want?*, Kuhn develops an alternative theory of the firm grounded in communication studies and informed by the neo-materialist philosophy of Deleuze and Guattari (1983). Firms, Kuhn argues, are not unitary actors but "authority machines" (p. 18) composed of shifting constellations of people and practices. Rather than generating a single objective, firms produce and communicate multiple, sometimes conflicting goals, articulated through what Kuhn calls "authoritative texts" (p. 101). These texts codify firms' promises of value and claims to property. They help construct and maintain attachments via three communicative mechanisms: *boundarying*, *branding*, and *binding*—the pillars of Kuhn's theory of the communicative firm under contemporary capitalism.

In Kuhn's framework, boundarying refers to how firms delineate their scope and identity through communicative practices, thereby distinguishing themselves from other organizations and environments. Branding encompasses the ways in which firms communicate their values and missions to external audiences, aiming to elicit recognition, meaning, and alignment. Binding captures how these messages cultivate internal and external attachment, from employee loyalty to customer engagement, through shared meanings and affiliations. These three concepts provide an interpretive lens distinct from more-conventional theories of the firm, such as the neoclassical economics firm as a "production function" (p. 6), the transaction cost economics firm as a "nexus of contracts" (p. 46), or the resource-based view of firms as bundles of "resources and capabilities" (p. 53). Since conventional theories of the firm have overlooked communication and sociopsychological aspects, Kuhn develops the argument for a "Communicative Theory of the Firm" (p. 21), which is contrasted with these other theories in Chapter 2. In doing so, Kuhn problematizes through a communication lens essential concepts such as governance, capabilities, and power within firms.

Kuhn situates firms as political arenas in which convergent and divergent interests are debated in socio-technical assemblages and enacted through authoritative discourse. Rather than seeking a singular purpose, firms reflect

the dynamic interplay of competing goals, preferences, and power relations in their multiplicity. This view situates the firm as a communicative and political space in which authority both enables and constrains action.

Kuhn illustrates these concepts through a rich set of case studies. The book examines historical cases such as the British East India Company during colonial times and the Anglo American Mining Company during and after apartheid in South Africa. He also analyzes contemporary cases, including the Chinese fast-fashion company Shein and the American cryptocurrency company Coinbase. The cases illustrate how communication practices influence firm boundaries, individual identities, and relationships across various temporal and geographic contexts.

ASQ readers interested in the theoretical foundations of Kuhn's work will find Chapters 3 and 4 instrumental. These chapters engage deeply with Deleuze and Guattari's philosophical concepts, including but not limited to assemblage theory, deterritorialization/reterritorialization, and the notion of becoming. Kuhn uses these concepts to explain why firms embody multiple and heterogeneous purposes, how they codify and crystallize particular meanings and missions in their "authoritative texts" (p. 101), and how they may gradually become what they want or desire. Although these chapters are conceptually dense and at times challenging, which is unsurprising given Deleuze and Guattari's influence, these sections offer readers the epistemological grounding needed to understand the fundamental assumptions of Kuhn's argument.

Chapter 6 offers a particularly compelling empirical application of the theory. It focuses on AmpVille, a pseudonym startup accelerator in Boulder, Colorado, which supports early-stage ventures by providing mentorship, networking, and access to venture capital. Kuhn uses the case to show how inclusion in the accelerator program serves as a branding mechanism for startups, while equity-sharing agreements and mentorship relationships create binding attachments among founders, investors, and the accelerator itself. The chapter highlights how the accelerator mediates multiple purposes, such as supporting entrepreneurial development while enhancing its own legitimacy, and enabling venture capital investments in the startup while ensuring financial resources for the accelerator itself.

An aspect that Kuhn could have further explored is the communicative theory's potential broader application to other organizations, such as public and non-profit organizations. The multiplicity of goals and purposes, the dynamic assemblage, and the strategies of boundarying, branding, and binding are not only present but perhaps more intensively expressed in public agencies and NGOs. For instance, studies have shown that public initiatives aiming to deliver superior services to citizens depend on dynamic negotiations and collaboration among participants with multiple distinct goals (Chown & Inoue, 2025; Lazzarini et al., 2020). Similarly, non-profit organizations and even social movements design complex strategies to bind partners to their causes and brand their activities in specific ways to achieve superior results (Odzimekowska, 2022; Seo et al., 2021). The conceptualization developed by Kuhn should not be restricted to firms, and its application to other organizational types emerges as an interesting avenue for future studies, particularly in organizations reflecting inherent, multiple objectives.

Overall, the book introduces a novel lens for examining firms as communicative and political entities. Kuhn's approach departs from dominant economic and strategic management theories of the firm, which often assume coherent firm objectives or focus on structural features such as inputs, contracts, and resources. By foregrounding communication and authority, Kuhn offers a more fluid, dynamic, and sociopolitical account of organizational purpose. While the text is conceptually intricate and philosophically ambitious, it rewards careful reading with fresh insights into how firms construct meaning, navigate complexity, and coordinate across divergent stakeholder interests.

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